

Cross-Asset Trading Playbook

Elite framework for VWAP, options flow, liquidity maps, session tactics, and real trade setups across forex, stocks, commodity futures, and crypto ETFs.

Edition: March 2026 | Purpose: execution manual, not market prophecy

Coverage	Forex, stocks, sector/index ETFs, commodity futures and ETPs, and crypto ETF / spot / perp complexes.
Core edge	Use the same five-lens process in every market: context, reference price, liquidity, trigger, and risk.

Core thesis

A seasoned trader does not ask, "Is this a good chart?" The better question is: who is active, where are they trapped, what reference price matters now, and what would force them to act?

Educational only. Adapt everything to your instrument, data source, fees, leverage, and risk limits.

01 How to Use This Playbook

The goal is not to memorize patterns. **The goal is to recognize when a market is being forced to move.**

Section	What it gives you
02 Cross-Asset Lens	A fast read on what truly drives each asset, which reference price matters, and where flow is likely to cluster.
03 VWAP + Options Flow	A way to blend value/acceptance with hedging pressure and positioning, instead of treating VWAP as a standalone signal.
04 Liquidity Maps	Asset-by-asset magnets, sweep zones, trap locations, and the confirmation that separates a true break from a stop run.
05 Session Strategies	When each market tends to expand, balance, pin, or mean-revert - and when it is smarter to do nothing.
06 Real Trade Setups	Repeatable templates organized from beginner to expert, with entry, stop, target, and invalidation logic.
07 Risk + Review	Sizing, execution discipline, daily stop rules, and a journal framework that helps good setups survive and weak ones get demoted.

Universal trade loop

- Define regime first: trend, balance, squeeze, event, or unwind.
- Mark the reference price that matters now: session VWAP, event AVWAP, prior settlement, or prior close.
- Map obvious liquidity above and below: prior highs/lows, option strikes, round numbers, roll/funding zones.
- Wait for acceptance, rejection, or reclaim - not just a touch.
- Size from invalidation, then review whether the setup deserves to stay in your playbook.

Three operating laws: price seeks liquidity, value shifts after catalysts, and time-of-day changes the quality of every signal.

02 Cross-Asset Framework at a Glance

Each market rewards a different kind of patience. Use the table below to choose the right reference price and the right source of confirmation before you think about entry.

Asset	What actually drives it	Best reference price	Liquidity + options read
Forex	Relative rates, central-bank path, inflation, and macro data. Trend quality improves when London and New York agree on direction.	Session VWAP from your feed or a liquid futures proxy, plus previous day high/low and session opens.	Asia range, round numbers, prior day extremes, option-cut zones, and listed futures-option strikes. Trap: treating spot FX VWAP as centralized truth.
Stocks / ETFs	Earnings, sector rotation, index flows, and whether the gap is being accepted or rejected.	Open VWAP, event AVWAP, prior close, and the first balance area after the open.	Overnight high/low, opening range, gap fill, large option strikes, and dealer gamma pin/release zones. Trap: chasing the first impulse without a hold above/below VWAP.
Commodities	Physical supply/demand, inventories, weather/geopolitics, and the futures curve.	Session VWAP, prior settlement, pit/electronic extremes, and event anchor after reports.	Inventory-report spikes, roll levels, delivery references, obvious swing highs/lows, and listed-option strikes. Trap: ignoring term structure or report timing.
Crypto ETFs / crypto	Liquidity, ETF flows, funding, narrative shifts, and where leveraged traders can be squeezed.	Cash-session VWAP for the ETF plus 24-7 spot/perp VWAP and the most relevant weekly AVWAP.	Overnight high/low, weekend extremes, round numbers, liquidation clusters, ETF cash-session pivots, and listed-option strikes. Trap: applying cash-equity logic to a 24-7 tape.

Fast read

If you are unsure which reference price to trust, use the narrowest anchor the market is clearly respecting. Intraday traders usually start with session VWAP; after a major catalyst, an event-anchored VWAP often becomes the real line in the sand.

03 VWAP + Options Flow Across All Asset Classes

VWAP is not a setup by itself. **It becomes powerful when it sits next to a level that forces participation.**

Forex

- VWAP read: use session VWAP from a consistent feed or a liquid futures proxy; value shifts matter more than tick precision.
- Options read: option-cut zones, barrier chatter, and listed futures-option strikes matter when visible.
- Best combo: break above Asia range, hold above session VWAP, then ask whether New York can keep value higher.
- Nuance: spot FX is decentralized, so consistency of your data is more important than false precision.

Stocks / ETFs

- VWAP read: opening VWAP and event AVWAP tell you whether the gap or catalyst is being accepted.
- Options read: call/put walls, gamma pin, zero-DTE pressure, and dealer hedging identify likely reaction zones.
- Best combo: trend days pull back to VWAP and leave quickly; weak gaps keep re-entering it.
- Nuance: the first impulse matters less than the first successful retest.

Commodities

- VWAP read: session VWAP around pit/electronic handoff shows whether the report spike became new value or just noise.
- Options read: liquid listed-option strikes and roll/expiry weeks can redirect otherwise clean trends.
- Best combo: event impulse + hold above VWAP + curve confirmation often supports a second leg.
- Nuance: you can be right on direction and still trade badly if you ignore the curve or calendar.

Crypto ETFs / crypto

- VWAP read: separate ETF cash-session VWAP from 24-7 spot/perp VWAP; each can lead at different hours.
- Options read: listed-option strikes, perp funding, basis, and ETF-flow alignment can reinforce or break a setup.
- Best combo: cash-open reclaim of the overnight range while spot/perps confirm the move.
- Nuance: overheated funding can overpower a pretty VWAP signal.

Anchoring rules that actually matter

- Use daily/session VWAP for intraday execution, especially after the first true balance forms.
- Use event-anchored VWAP after catalysts such as earnings, CPI, inventory reports, central-bank decisions, or major crypto headlines.
- Use weekly AVWAP when several sessions are orbiting the same level and daily structure gets noisy.
- If a market is thin or decentralized, validate VWAP with higher-timeframe structure and the most liquid proxy you trust.

Options-flow visibility varies by product and vendor. When the options picture is weak, lean harder on acceptance around value and less on strike folklore.

04 Liquidity Maps per Asset

Think of a liquidity map as a list of places where somebody will be forced to do business: trapped breakout traders, stop clusters, hedgers, or late participants who need to act.

Forex

- Prime magnets: Asia high/low, previous day high/low, round numbers, major data-candle extremes, London and New York opens.
- Best read: watch whether the sweep is reclaimed quickly or whether price can hold outside the range after the first retest.
- Best confirmation: a reclaim back through session VWAP supports a fade; clean acceptance outside value supports continuation.
- Extra edge: option cut, 10 a.m. New York, and London-close behavior often decide whether the first move sticks.

Stocks / ETFs

- Prime magnets: overnight high/low, previous close, opening range, gap fill, event AVWAP, and large nearby option strikes.
- Best read: the first push is often emotional; the first hold above or below VWAP is the better truth signal.
- Best confirmation: breadth, sector-leader confirmation, and tape speed around heavy strikes.
- Extra edge: expiry, rebalance, and index events can create pinning before release.

Commodities

- Prime magnets: prior settlement, pit/electronic highs and lows, report spikes, roll gaps, delivery references, and benchmark levels.
- Best read: commodity markets often overshoot obvious levels before revealing true acceptance.
- Best confirmation: curve behavior, related markets, and whether the move survives the first retracement after an event.
- Extra edge: event timing matters more than most chart patterns. Know the calendar before you trust the setup.

Crypto ETFs / crypto

- Prime magnets: overnight high/low, weekend extremes, round numbers, liquidation clusters, ETF cash-session pivots, and previous week highs/lows.
- Best read: separate ETF cash-hours impulse from 24-7 underlying noise; they can disagree for a while.
- Best confirmation: spot-perp basis, funding normalization, and alignment between ETF tape and the underlying.
- Extra edge: thin weekend liquidity makes false breaks common, especially near obvious levels.

How to read the map in real time

- **Touch and reject:** mean-reversion candidate, provided value does not shift.
- **Sweep and reclaim:** trap / reversal candidate, especially when price returns through VWAP or the opening range.
- **Break and hold outside value:** continuation candidate; the market is accepting the new price.
- **Chop around the level:** no edge yet; wait until the market proves where value belongs.

05 Session-Based Strategies

Time-of-day is not background information. It changes the character of liquidity, the reliability of VWAP, and whether a level is likely to pin price or launch it.

Session-Based Flow Map

Conceptual sequence only - exact venue hours, daylight savings, and product calendars vary.

Forex	Asia range build	London expansion	Overlap impulse	NY handoff	Rollover
Stocks / ETFs	Premarket discovery	Open drive	Midday balance	Power hour	After-hours
Crypto / ETFs	Asia impulse	Europe takeover	US macro + ETF flow	Late-US reset	Weekend / 24-7 drift
	Build context	Expect expansion	Check acceptance	Separate trend from fade	Thin liquidity / reduced edge

Conceptual session sequence. Verify exact trading hours, DST shifts, and event calendars for each product.

Asset	Highest-quality window	What tends to work	What often fails
Forex	London open and London/NY overlap	Range expansion, pullback continuation, and macro follow-through after acceptance outside value.	Fading a clean post-data break before absorption appears.
Stocks / ETFs	Open drive and power hour	Open-drive pullbacks, midday VWAP reclaim on trend days, and close-aligned continuation.	Forcing trades in lifeless midday tape or ignoring the gap context.
Commodities	Pit open, benchmark windows, and scheduled reports	Impulse + hold, second-leg continuation, and event fades only after acceptance fails.	Trading blind into inventory, auction, or settlement windows.
Crypto / ETFs	ETF cash open, US macro windows, Asia follow-through, weekend extremes for fades	Cash-hour expansion, squeeze/release trades, and weekend mean reversion back to value.	Assuming Sunday liquidity behaves like a weekday tape.

When not to trade

- When the market is sitting between obvious levels and no session participants are forcing a decision.
- When your setup depends on volume but the active session has not started yet.
- When a scheduled catalyst is minutes away and would reset all of your carefully drawn levels.

06A Real Trade Setups - Beginner Tier

These are the cleanest structures to repeat because they rely on obvious levels, obvious sessions, and obvious invalidation.

Setup 1 - Opening Drive -> VWAP Pullback

Best market	Liquid single stocks, index ETFs, and sector ETFs after a gap or a clear catalyst.
Conditions	Overnight range is clean, the first impulse leaves value, and sector/breadth support the move.
Entry	Enter on the first pullback that defends VWAP or event AVWAP after the opening range break. The short version is the mirror image.
Stop / invalidation	Below the pullback low, or back through VWAP if rejection is immediate and obvious.
Targets	Opening-range extension, prior day high/low, gap objective, and the next major option strike.
Avoid when	The gap runs directly into higher-timeframe resistance and price cannot hold above VWAP after two or three tests.

Setup 2 - London Breakout -> Retest

Best market	Major forex pairs around the London open or after high-impact macro data.
Conditions	Asia range is defined, macro bias is aligned, and there is enough room to the next obvious liquidity magnet.
Entry	Let the breakout occur first, then use the retest of the Asia edge or session VWAP as the actual decision point.
Stop / invalidation	Back inside the prior range or through the opposite side of the retest structure.
Targets	Previous day high/low, round number, London extension, or New York handoff target.
Avoid when	The breakout slams directly into the previous day extreme and instantly loses acceptance.

Beginner rule

If the setup is not obvious enough to explain in one sentence, it is probably not a beginner trade. Skip it and wait for cleaner structure.

06B Real Trade Setups - Intermediate Tier

These trades are still structured, but they demand better judgment around event timing, confirmation, and the quality of the value shift.

Setup 3 - Event Impulse -> Value Hold

Best market	Commodity futures and related ETFs around inventories, reports, benchmark windows, or major macro releases.
Conditions	The event creates a clear imbalance, but the move only becomes tradeable when price holds or reclaims session VWAP after the first reaction.
Entry	Trade in the direction of the new value only after the first retracement fails and the tape proves the move can survive without the headline.
Stop / invalidation	Through the report-pivot or back through VWAP once the market has had a fair chance to hold it.
Targets	Prior swing high/low, measured move, second distribution zone, or settlement reference.
Avoid when	The first spike is fully retraced and volatility collapses back into pre-event balance.

Setup 4 - Cash Open Expansion vs Overnight Range

Best market	BTC or ETH complex when the ETF cash session aligns with, accelerates, or cleanly rejects the overnight move.
Conditions	Overnight range is tight or clearly trending, ETF open adds participation, and funding is not already dangerously crowded.
Entry	Long on a cash-session reclaim of the overnight high with ETF and underlying aligned, or short on the inverse failure back into value.
Stop / invalidation	Back inside the overnight range, or through the cash-open pivot that defined the shift in control.
Targets	Round number, weekly high/low, liquidation cluster, and cash-session extension target.
Avoid when	Funding is already extreme, ETF tape diverges from the underlying, or the move is too extended before cash participation arrives.

Intermediate filter

Do not confuse a headline reaction with a value shift. The trade improves only when price can hold the new area after the first emotional burst.

06C Real Trade Setups - Expert Tier

Expert setups are often simple on paper but hard in practice because they require restraint: wait for the trap to reveal itself before committing.

Setup 5 - Liquidity Sweep -> VWAP Reclaim

Best market	Any liquid market with an obvious prior high/low, session extreme, or crowded public level.
Conditions	The level is widely visible, the sweep happens quickly, and price then returns through VWAP or the opening range instead of accepting outside it.
Entry	Enter on the reclaim and hold, not on the first touch. The reclaim proves the stop run failed to create real acceptance.
Stop / invalidation	Beyond the sweep extreme; use smaller size when volatility expands sharply.
Targets	Session VWAP, midpoint of the prior range, opposite side of value, or the next inventory pocket.
Avoid when	The sweep becomes true acceptance outside value and there is no sign of absorption or failed continuation.

Setup 6 - Options Strike Pin / Gamma Release

Best market	Index and sector ETFs, large-cap stocks, and liquid commodity/index options when nearby strikes dominate the session.
Conditions	Heavy open interest or obvious strike sensitivity is present, price repeatedly reacts there, and VWAP shows whether the market is pinning or beginning to escape.
Entry	Fade the pin while price remains trapped; flip to continuation only when the strike breaks and price can hold beyond VWAP.
Stop / invalidation	Through the strike on true acceptance, not merely on a wick or a fast one-minute overshoot.
Targets	The next major strike, range extension, rebalance window, or close-driven continuation.
Avoid when	You cannot identify where the real liquidity sits, or an expiry/event is too close for clean read-through.

Expert warning

Expert setups usually fail because the trader enters before the trap is fully visible. Wait for the reclaim, hold, or release. Precision matters more than frequency.

07 Risk Framework, Execution SOP, and Review Loop

A strong playbook is useless if leverage, position size, or ego turns every small error into a large loss.

Asset	Hidden risk	Better stop logic	Sizing note
Forex	Leverage makes small timing errors expensive, especially around data and session handoffs.	Use structural invalidation: back inside range, back through VWAP, or through the retest pivot.	If news risk is near, reduce size before you widen the stop.
Stocks / ETFs	Gap risk, earnings, and option pinning can distort otherwise clean intraday reads.	Place the stop where acceptance truly fails, not one tick beyond the last micro swing.	Size smaller when the open is disorderly or when the name is event-driven.
Commodities	Event spikes, curve shifts, and thin pockets can turn normal pullbacks into violent air pockets.	Use report pivots, settlement references, or clearly failed retracements as the invalidation point.	Calendar risk deserves a size haircut even when the chart looks perfect.
Crypto / ETFs	Overnight and weekend liquidity can vanish quickly, and funding squeezes can extend beyond "reasonable" levels.	Anchor the stop to the cash-open pivot, overnight range, or liquidation level that defined the trade.	When funding and leverage are crowded, trade smaller and take profits more deliberately.

Execution SOP

- Mark overnight and prior-session extremes before the market becomes emotional.
- Anchor session VWAP and the single most relevant event AVWAP.
- List the two strongest liquidity magnets above and below price.
- Write one continuation plan and one reversal plan before you enter.
- Add only after the market proves your thesis; never add simply because you want a better average price.
- Stop the day after two failed A-setups or after your pre-defined max drawdown in R.

Weekly review questions

- Which session produced your highest-quality trades, and which session tempted you into noise?
- Which level type paid best this week: VWAP, prior-day extreme, option strike, or event anchor?
- Where did you enter before acceptance was proven?
- Which setup deserves promotion, demotion, or removal next week?

08 Journal Template and 30-Second Pre-Trade Script

Use this last page as a template. The quality of your notes determines how quickly your real edge becomes visible.

Field	What to log	Questions to answer	Minimum standard
Context	Asset, date, session, catalyst	Who was active and why now?	One sentence only.
Map	VWAP/AVWAP, prior extremes, strike or funding zones	Where will traders be forced to act?	At least two magnets each side.
Trigger	Reclaim, rejection, acceptance, trend pullback, or event hold	What proved the thesis?	Name the proof, not the feeling.
Risk	Entry, stop, size, first target	Was size based on invalidation?	Define R before entry.
Exit	Why you took profits or stopped	Did the market deny the thesis or just pause?	Separate process from outcome.

30-second pre-trade script

- What regime am I in right now?
- Which reference price matters now?
- Where is the nearest forced participation above and below?
- What would prove continuation, and what would prove trap?
- Is my size built from invalidation - or from emotion?

The best playbooks stay simple because they are designed to survive real-time pressure.

Next-week decision sheet

Promote: Which setup earned more trust this week?

Refine: Which setup works, but only with tighter conditions?

Remove: Which trade idea looked good in theory and failed in live flow?

Write short notes. If a setup needs a paragraph to justify it, it probably needs more filtering.